

Study Questions: Agents

1. Define **Agents** in your own words, specifically as it applies to Middle School.
2. How does the Free Energy Principle constrain our understanding of Agents?
3. Contrast the Classical view of Agents with the Active Inference view.
4. What are the three things that make someone an agent? Give an example of each one from your own life today.
5. Explain the difference between acting on **autopilot** and acting in **intentional mode**. When is each one useful?
6. Think of a time you and a friend disagreed about something. How could understanding that you each have different **mental models** help explain the disagreement?
7. In video games, what is the difference between a player character (PC) and a non-player character (NPC)? How does this compare to autopilot vs. intentional mode in real life?
8. You are deciding whether to raise your hand in class. Describe the goal, prediction, and decision your brain goes through in that moment.
9. Why does understanding that other people are agents with their own goals make you better at handling disagreements?
10. Give an example of a moment today when you were on autopilot. What would have been different if you had switched to intentional mode?
11. Your friend always sits in the same seat at lunch. Are they acting as an agent or on autopilot? How can you tell the difference?
12. A new student joins your class and seems unfriendly. Using the concept of agents and mental models, explain at least two reasons they might be acting that way.
13. What does it mean to "run a mental simulation"? Describe a situation where your brain simulates possible outcomes before you act.

14. If everyone around you is also an agent with their own goals, why is it impossible to control how other people behave? How does this idea help you in social situations?
15. Think of a choice you made this week that you are proud of. What goal, model, and prediction led to that choice?
16. Create a short "Agent Profile" for yourself that includes: your top three goals today, one prediction you are making right now, and one action you plan to take based on that prediction.
17. How could knowing about autopilot mode help you study better for a test? Give a specific strategy.
18. Explain why two people can watch the same event (like a basketball game) and have completely different opinions about what happened. Use the word "model" in your answer.
19. Is a thermostat an agent? It senses temperature, has a goal (target temp), and takes action (heating or cooling). Argue for or against.
20. Design a simple test you could use each day to check whether you are in autopilot or intentional mode. What question would you ask yourself?